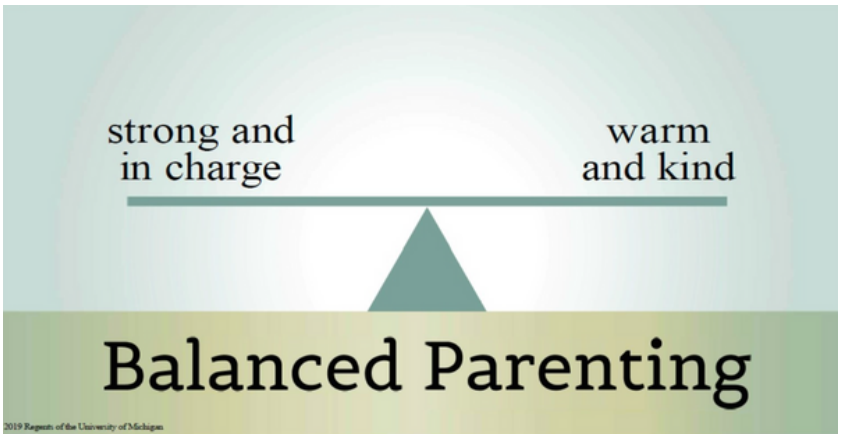
BALANCED PARENTING



STRONG & IN CHARGE

- Setting and maintaining limits (such as routines, consequences, safety)
- Encouraging them to explore and try new things
- Building confidence (“I know you can do it!”)
- Solving problems when they arise
- Being the "adult"' in your relationship with your child

Managing our own feelings so that we can help our children learn what to do with their own feelings

WARM & KIND

- Using a gentle tone of voice most of the time
- Being curious about their thoughts and feelings
- Validating their emotions ("It makes sense that you're scared, you've never done this before!")
- Soothing them when they are upset or scared
- In tune with their needs
- "I wonder if this feels extra hard right now because you're hungry and haven't had a snack yet"

Kids are made stronger and more resilient by kindness at home

ADAPTED FROM THE MOM POWER VIRTUAL GROUP CURRICULUM (MUZIK & ROSENBLUM ET AL., UNPUBLISHED MANUAL, 2021)

BALANCED CAREGIVING

SETTING AND MAINTAINING LIMITS IN A KIND WAY

- Gentle tone of voice while also maintaining routines and consistency
- Offer choices about small decisions within a routine (e.g., "It's time for bed, do you want to put on pjs or brush your teeth first?")
- **Being attuned** to their needs and **encouraging them** to face their fears
  - "I know it's hard AND I know you can do it! Let's take one small step together"
  - **I know better (not "kids should know better")**
- When something isn't working, taking a step back and think about how you could approach it differently to teach your child the skills they don't have yet
- When we both have big feelings, **I can manage my feelings and then help you manage yours**
- Asking for help so that you can cool off first, protecting a bit of time for yourself



Almost all of us find one of these two approaches more natural/easy

Learning to cope with some inconsistencies is a good skill for kids

Differences often contribute to conflict between co-parents/caregivers

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WHAT INFLUENCES OUR PARENTING APPROACH?

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Our own personalities

- Either strong & in charge or warm & kind tend to come more naturally to us

How we were parented

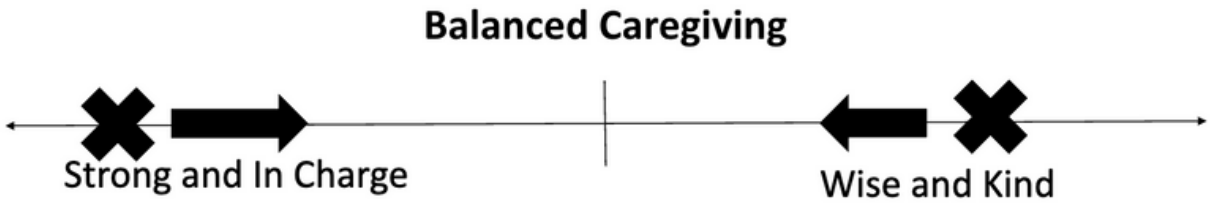
- Shapes our expectations and assumptions about parenting

Where/when we grew up (cultural norms)

- Common for men to be seen as weak for being warm/kind, women to be judged harshly for being strong and in charge

Our child's personality

- Kids with strong wills and big feelings often evoke stronger reactions/different parenting approaches from us compared to siblings with less intense emotions



Our kids need **each of us** to be **both** strong and in charge and wise and kind



While we will never be perfectly "balanced," moving closer to the center **helps our kids** and can **make parenting easier** over time

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NAVIGATING DIFFERENCES WITH PARTNERS/CAREGIVERS

No one's approach is "right" or "wrong"

We are all working towards balanced parenting

Negotiate a **compromise**

Should bring you closer to "balanced" parenting!



APPRECIATE EACH OTHER'S STRENGTHS

- Point out the positive benefits of their parenting style
- Play to their strengths (e.g., "strong and in charge" does morning routine)
- Compliment them when they take steps towards balanced caregiving!
- Remember, **you are on the <u>same team</u>** and want the best for your child!



